

Open by Design: the *Cultura* Project

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ABSTRACT

This chapter examines the *Cultura* Project from the perspective of open education. *Cultura* is a telecollaborative project to develop intercultural understanding between groups of students from different cultures. Initially developed in French at MIT, it has been widely adapted by instructors at other institutions. After examining the main features of a *Cultura* exchange, the chapter looks at how the intrinsically open design of the project creates affordances for both learners and educators in four main areas: pedagogy, materials development, technology, and professional development. “Openness” is manifest both in the particular features of a *Cultura* exchange as well as in the systematic ways the *Cultura* model, technological platform, associated materials, and classroom methodologies have been made available to instructors who have in turn adapted them to their own contexts. As an open system and part of a culture of openness, *Cultura* contributes significantly to pedagogy, technology, materials development, and professional development in world language education.

INTRODUCTION

Cultura is a telecollaborative project aimed at developing intercultural understanding between groups of students from different cultures. First created in a French language class at MIT by a team of three instructors (Gilberte Furstenberg, Sabine Levet and Shoggy Waryn), it initially connected students in the US and in France. Since its inception in 1997 it has been widely adapted in other languages at other institutions, and received a Special Recognition Award from the American Council on Education for its “Innovative Use of Technology to Promote Internationalization” (American Council on Education, 2010).

Two emerging technologies that became widely available in the mid-1990s were essential to *Cultura*: the Web made it possible for remote groups of students to access the same documents posted online, and online discussion forums enabled communication between these groups. *Cultura* benefited from open source web technology for developing its website, and from a collaborative, web-based environment developed at MIT (MetaMedia) available to the whole MIT community to enable communication via online forums.

In turn, since its creation *Cultura* has been openly accessible to instructors and the community at large through multiple channels: a website that provides both pedagogical resources (including an archive of past exchanges) and open technology tools to easily manage exchanges; conferences and workshops; and one-on-one support via email, phone

or Skype. The commitment to offer concrete support to instructors who want to adapt *Cultura* has been part of every stage of the project's development over the years. For instance, when, after receiving initial funding from the Consortium for Language Learning and Teaching (1997), *Cultura* received a three-year grant from the National Endowment from the Humanities (1998), part of its stated mission was to make *Cultura* open. In 2008 *Cultura* received additional funding from the French Initiatives Endowment Funds at MIT to make its website more user-friendly and interactive, and to reconfigure the MIT-developed program enabling instructors to easily manage a *Cultura* exchange (Exchange Management Tool) so that it would be available for free to instructors lacking technology support at their own institutions. It also offered the possibility to have their exchanges hosted at MIT.

In Part 1 of this chapter we will look at the main features of a *Cultura* exchange and examine how *Cultura's* collaborative, comparative and constructivist approach and its modular design effectively make this project highly adaptable to different contexts. In Part 2 we will discuss different ways in which *Cultura* has actively been made available, accessible, and usable by the FL community at large. In Part 3, we will reflect on how *Cultura* has evolved through multiple collaborations and adaptations, and see what types of discussions have been taking place among instructors, partners, developers and adopters in this open context.

1.0 - Main features of a *Cultura* exchange

In this section we will first look at how a *Cultura* exchange is structured, present its approach and methodology, describe the types of materials used and explain how students work with them. Illustrating the process with examples from the forums, we will show how this model of telecollaboration opens the classroom to a multiplicity of voices.

1.1 Need

The call for teaching culture in language classes has been central to the profession for many years. The *Standards for Foreign Language Learning*, published by the National Standards in Foreign Language Education Project, US Dept. of Education (1996) in collaboration with the American Council on the Teaching of Foreign Languages (ACTFL), gave a large place to culture. On the occasion of the publication of the revised *World-Readiness Standards for Learning Languages* (National Standards in Foreign Language Education Project, US Dept. of Education, 2015), Marty Abbott, ACTFL's Executive Director, noted that "the 21st century learner faces a future of work that increasingly requires collaboration and communication with people from other cultures, whether on a local assembly line or in a boardroom across the globe" (American Council on the Teaching of Foreign Languages, 2015).

The 2007 report of the Modern Language Association (MLA) Ad Hoc Committee on Foreign Languages, "New Structures for a Changed World," stressed the need to train students to become "educated speakers who have deep translingual and transcultural competence" and called for a curricular reform that would "situate language study in

cultural, historical, geographic, and cross-cultural frames within the context of humanistic learning." One of the recommendations of the report was that students should be "trained to reflect on the world and themselves through the lens of another language and culture" (MLA Ad Hoc Committee on Foreign Languages, 2007).

Since the mid-1990s, the Council of Europe as well has been calling for the development of intercultural competence. Stressing that intercultural competence is not acquired automatically and needs to be learned and practiced, it has been supporting instructors through a number of publications on intercultural learning, such as *Developing the Intercultural Dimension in Language Teaching: A Practical Introduction for Teachers* (Byram, Gribkova, & Starkey, 2002).

1.2 Approach

Developing intercultural understanding, in *Cultura*, means engaging in a dynamic online interaction with partners from another culture. In a *Cultura* exchange, two groups of students from two different cultures compare similar materials from their respective cultures juxtaposed online, such as answers to intercultural questionnaires, statistics and surveys, films and their remakes, images, commercials, newspaper articles or websites of international companies. They discuss the materials with their own group in class and with their online partners via asynchronous forums.

The ability to communicate online would not, in and of itself, automatically result in intercultural understanding. The pedagogy behind *Cultura* is built upon a constructivist approach, unfolding around specific materials and tasks. The description that follows presents a 'classic' *Cultura* exchange. Because *Cultura* can be freely adapted to different contexts and cultures, there have been multiple variations regarding materials, language use, and types of partnerships. But it is important to understand how the process unfolds, to appreciate how technology supports the pedagogical goal.

1.3 Methodology

In the first stage of a *Cultura* exchange, the students are asked to respond online, anonymously and in their L1, to a series of three questionnaires. For instance, in an exchange between MIT and a French university, the MIT students will answer in English to prompts in English, and the French university students will answer in French to prompts in French. For the first questionnaire, students are asked what words they would associate with different word prompts, such as "family," "success," "individualism." For the second questionnaire, they complete sentences such as "A good parent is someone who ...," "A rude person is someone who ...," "A good job is..." For the third questionnaire, they have to say how they would react in various hypothetical situations such as: "You see a student cheating during an exam," or "You have been waiting in line, and someone cuts in front of you." The goal of these questionnaires is to collect raw materials that the students will then analyze and discuss. There might not be a perfect choice of equivalent words and

expressions in both languages for the prompts, but this lack of exact equivalency is often discussed in the forums -- an apt example of how *Cultura* students have ample opportunities to reflect on the very issue of translation and adaptation.

The decision to have students answer in L1, and later in the exchange to write their comments on the forums in L1 as well (which means that the forums happen in two languages, with both sides of the exchange writing in L1, and consequently reading in L2), was linked from the start to the notion that language is culture. "Language shapes who you are" (Kramsch & Gerhards, 2012, p. 75). In Claire Kramsch's formulation, passing between languages implies moving between different modes of thought, and different modes of being (Kramsch, 2018). Language is not only about getting your message across. In the words of famed semiotician Mikhail Bakhtin, "Language is not a neutral medium... it is populated – overpopulated – with the intentions of others" (Bakhtin, 1982, p. 294). As the MLA Report recognized, "Culture is represented not only in events, texts, buildings, artworks, cuisines, and many other artifacts but also in language itself. Expressions such as 'the pursuit of happiness,' 'liberté, égalité, fraternité,' and 'la Raza' connote cultural dimensions that extend well beyond their immediate translation" (MLA Ad Hoc Committee on Foreign Languages, 2007).

When the responses from each group in the exchange are published online side-by-side, the juxtaposition allows differences to emerge, as shown in Fig. 1.

Fig. 1, archived exchange from the Cultura website

Cultura Archived Exchanges / 2006 / Spring / MIT / École Polytechnique / Word Association /	
Individualism	Individualisme
awareness, self-determination	argent, vitesse
beliefs, strength	égoïsme, américain
independence, freedom	égoïsme, argent
independence, selfish	égoïsme, vision à court terme, moderne
independence, sovereignty, pride	égoïste, défaut, méchant
intelligence, ideas	égoïsme, nécessaire, modernité
liberal, integrity	égoïsme, requin
loneliness, stubbornness	décadence, antipathie, perte
motivation, isolation, pioneering	défaut, développé
narcissism	démocratie, capitalisme, majorité
necessary, enlightening	mal moderne, français, à combattre
open-mindedness, independence	méchanceté, égoïsme
political	Polytechnique, égoïsme, fermé
school of thought, weird	racisme, égoïsme, mépris
self, modern	se battre
society, reality, self	solitude, opportunisme
success, drive	solitude, égoïsme, société
understatement, values	survie, force, honnêteté
uniqueness, autonomy	
United States, personality, freedom	

This example from a US/France exchange contains many cognates on the French side, which will make it easier for non-readers of French to get a sense of the effects of juxtaposition. Other examples with many different prompts and in different languages are available on the *Cultura* archived exchanges (<http://cultura.mit.edu/cultura-exchanges-archive>).

These responses to the intercultural questionnaires provide an entry point into both cultures, and are the first items analyzed by students online and in class, over a period of three weeks. The first week, students discuss the word associations; the second week, the sentence completions; and the third week, the reactions to situations, in class and on the forums.

The first task for students is to analyze and compare the answers to three prompts of their choice in the Word Associations, individually before coming to class. On average, there are about ten to twelve prompts per category, so usually all the different topics are covered, even if the instructor does not assign them specifically. Performing this comparison by themselves in advance prepares students to work with their peers in class as well as online. The step-by-step process is carefully scaffolded, and starts with asking students to take a close look at the materials: after printing the juxtaposed answers, they work on the vocabulary, count and circle words to see what answers are used most often on each side, which ones appear on one side only. They regroup the responses and try to decide if they have a rather positive, neutral, or negative connotation -- a question which is occasionally brought back in the classroom discussions. For instance, the notion of power (*puissance*) that the French university students sometimes associate with the prompt "USA" can be seen as having a positive, neutral or negative connotation.

The students' task is organized around three questions, essential to the scaffolding process: a. What did you notice? Write down your observations; b. Why do you think the students from (other school) gave these answers? Make a hypothesis; c. What questions could you ask them to verify your hypothesis? Asking students to go through observations, hypotheses and questions enables them to analyze the materials and takes them out of the right/wrong duality with which they are familiar. They can always revise their hypotheses and understanding in the light of new elements brought into the conversation by their classmates or their online partners in the forums. During the classroom discussions (in L2), they are encouraged to always support their analysis with direct observations, and to directly quote the answers to the questionnaires and comments on the forums as evidence to support their point. In order to avoid generalizations or oversimplifications, whenever students come up with an observation about the other culture, they are encouraged to consider within what situations it seems to apply, and if there are situations where it does not apply. The whole group in class is important for this type of exercise, since all students can bring together, contrast and combine their different observations and interpretations.

There is a forum attached to each prompt. They are all open to all students, so that anyone can follow an entire conversation at a glance. They are written in L1, outside of class, but are referred to during class. Occasionally they allude to classroom discussions, as students bring back online what they have discussed with their peers. Even though the forums are asynchronous, it is expected that all students on both sides of the exchange will contribute within a specific period of time, generally a week, to ensure that there is truly a back and forth between them.

The instructors do not intervene directly in the forums, but again scaffold the process by providing expectations for participation. For example, they request that students post their observations, share their hypotheses and ask questions to verify them. Students also need to answer their partners' questions and react to their comments. When first joining a new topic, they need to read what has been said so far, so as to help move the conversation and not just

repeat observations that might have already been made. Over a week, they are expected to visit the same topics multiple times to continue the conversation.

The end goal of the forums is not to create a consensus among all students, but to enable them to engage with their online partners and progressively build a more nuanced view of the others' culture. They are never asked to come up with any definitive statement about the other culture, but to always re-examine their findings in the light of new materials and new points of view. Since the process is reciprocal, answering questions or reacting to hypotheses from their partners enables them to put their own culture in perspective.

1.4 Examples from the archived exchanges

The following examples from the archived exchanges will illustrate the types of interactions taking place between the two groups of students, and will show how the forums open the classroom to multiple voices.

Students share their observations, juxtaposing both sides:

"I noticed the emphasis of exhaustion in the opinions of American students and the emphasis on obligation regarding 'work' for the French" (Z., Work, Spring 2017).

"It seems to me, when I reading the answers, that for the Americans, the most important thing for a father or a mother is unconditional love, whereas for the French, their role as guide comes up more often." (*Il me semble, en lisant les réponses, que pour les américains, la chose la plus importante chez un père ou une mère est un amour inconditionnel, alors que pour les français, le rôle de guide revient plus souvent pour les parents.*) (A., Good parent, Spring 2013)

They make hypotheses:

It is possible that the idea of individualism goes against the French value of equality. (E., Individualism, Spring 2016)

They ask questions:

"The word 'education' seems only to appear on the French side. Does this refer to moral education or education related to schoolwork when children are young?" (M., Good parent, Spring 2016).

I'd like to know, from the perspective of the French students, what you think the most impactful part of French culture has been on a global scale? (A., France, Spring 2017)

They are intrigued and ask for their partners' opinion:

"Still I was surprised by an answer: 'A good parent puts their own needs second.' Do you think that a parent must really give up everything, sacrifice completely for his/her child?" (*Une réponse m'a tout de même intrigué : "A good parent puts their own needs second". Pensez-vous qu'un parent doit vraiment tout donner, "se sacrifier" complètement pour son enfant?*) (D., Good parent, Spring 2016)

They are aware of the risk of oversimplification:

"I disagree with what has been said so far about the relationship between parents and children in France. I think that we – us as much as you – give an overly simplistic view of it." (*Je ne suis pas d'accord avec ce qui a été dit sur la relation parent-enfant en France. Je trouve qu'on – nous comme vous – en donne une image trop caricaturale [...].*) (A., Good parent, Spring 2017)

They recognize that the answers reveal aspects of their own as much as the other culture that they had not considered:

"On the American side, words such as 'necessary' or 'difficult' show up a lot, whereas the French mention 'passion.' I was very surprised. I must say that I thought the Americans gave more value to work and saw it more positively, whereas the French have a rather bad reputation about it." (*Chez les américains, des mots comme "necessary" et "difficult" reviennent souvent, alors que les français mettent en avant la "passion". Cela m'a beaucoup surpris. Je dois dire que je pensais que les américains valorisaient plus le travail et ses aspects positifs, alors que les français ont plutôt mauvaise réputation dans ce domaine.*) (N., Work, Spring 2013)

They truly engage and try both to understand the others and be understood, trying to work past apparent disagreements or misunderstandings:

"I agree with you, maybe I didn't express myself properly before." (M., Good parent, Spring 2013)

"I think the difference that I was trying to articulate has to do with the way French and American parents support their children." (C., Good parent, Spring 2017)

They look beyond first impressions:

"It seems to me that most of the American students find individualism positive, creative; meanwhile, the French seem to see it as negative [...]. Is there a better word in French that describes someone who doesn't follow others/just do things to fit in?" (S., Individualism, Spring 2016)

They get answers:

S., I would say that the word equivalent to 'individualism' in French would be 'non-conformiste.' (*S., je dirais que le mot qui équivaut à 'individualism' serait 'non-conformiste.'* (M., Individualism, Spring 2016)

They address their own group as well as the other group, and do not assume they speak for all:

"Well, that's the way I see it. I would love to hear what my compatriots think about it." (*Après, c'est ma vision des choses. J'aimerais bien savoir ce que mes compatriotes en pensent.*) (A., Good parent, Spring 2013)

They speak from their own experience:

"I personally experienced a culture shock when I came to the United States 7 years ago and found strangers smiling and saying hello after making eye contact." (Z. Stranger smiles, Spring 2017)

"I come from a country other than the US, so I can look at both sides and see how they compare. In my country, there is a bit of both, but slowly it can be seen that it is becoming increasingly taboo to correct/advise a child against wrong if he/she is not your own. Does this taboo exist at all in France?" (D., Well-behaved child, Spring 2013)

They present a society that is changing (here, in the answer to the question above):

"Yes and no. In the past it was not taboo, but it becoming more and more so." (*Oui et non. Ça ne l'était pas et ça le devient de plus en plus.*) (A., Well-behaved child, Spring 2013)

"In the time of my grandparents, school had as much authority on children as their parents. I find it shocking." (*Du temps de mes grands parents, l'école avait la même autorité sur l'enfant que le parent. Ce qui me choque, soit dit en passant.*) (A., Well-behaved child, Spring 2013)

They reflect on stereotypes:

"I come from the suburbs of Paris and see that the French have a negative opinion about them. What annoys me the most is that the media in France as well as abroad give a negative view of the suburbs. They give the impression that all suburbs are ghettos, but that is not the case. Most of them are nice places to live, and that's where I feel best." (*Je viens de la banlieue parisienne et je constate que les Français ont une vision négative. Ce qui me désole le plus, c'est la vision négative de la banlieue véhiculée par les médias aussi bien en France qu'à l'étranger. Ils donnent l'impression que toutes les banlieues sont des ghettos, alors que ce n'est pas le cas. La majorité sont des lieux de vie agréables, et c'est là que je me sens le mieux.*) (S., Suburbs, Spring 2013)

They question their own assumptions:

"On the American side, words such as "necessary" and "difficult" appear many times, whereas the French mention "passion". That surprised me a lot. I must say that I thought that Americans attached a lot of value to work and its positive aspects, whereas the French have a rather bad reputation. [...] I wonder if we have not tried to contradict these clichés." (*Chez les américains, des mots comme "necessary" et "difficult" reviennent souvent, alors que les français mettent en avant la "passion". Cela m'a beaucoup surpris. Je dois dire que je pensais que les américains valorisaient plus le travail et ses aspects positifs, alors que les français ont plutôt mauvaise réputation dans ce domaine. [...] Je me demande si nous n'avons pas essayé de contredire ces clichés...*) (N., Work, Spring 2013)

1.5 Skill development and skill transfer

The types of interactions illustrated above demonstrate what intercultural learning means in *Cultura*. Students, engaging with others on the forums, become aware that language and culture play a role in the way they perceive the world, and that learning is a co-construction; that it is necessary to question assumptions and stereotypes and one's own culture; that the frame of reference, or context, is important; that they all occupy multiple positions. As they learn to interpret text and reflect on the different meanings attached to different contexts, they develop literacy skills that they can apply when working with different materials.

The intercultural questionnaires are just the starting point. Depending on their pedagogical goals, instructors can decide to include different modules in the exchange, around other types of materials used in a comparative way.

Comparing a French film and its American remake was part of the very early *Cultura* exchanges at MIT, as a way to look at the underlying cultural frameworks revealed by the two versions of a film. It can be easily adapted to different cultures, as a large number of foreign films have been adapted, over the years, for an American audience. A scene-by-scene comparative analysis enables students, focusing on the story and the characters, to observe what has been changed in the remake, and reflect on what this reveals about each culture.

Working with statistics and surveys after the questionnaires leads students to open up their range of investigation. Their informants for the first three weeks of an exchange are a small number of students from their partner school who cannot be seen as representative of an entire cultural group. So students are asked to look for statistics and national surveys and say how, in their opinion, they illustrate, explain, or seem to contradict an aspect of the other – or their own – culture that was discussed in the first part of the exchange.

Working with images makes students think about how to communicate about their culture visually. For instance they can illustrate different aspects of their daily life, such as where they live, eat, and study, take pictures of their schedules, and photograph visuals found around campus. They can also try to clarify visually the meaning of a concept in their own

culture, or work on advertising pages in magazines or websites. This can be done in cross-cultural teams, each one contributing images around a similar topic, and then reflecting and commenting on what these pictures reveal about both cultures.

Work with commercials can focus on the differences in the way similar products are advertised in the two cultures. Students can also analyze commercials that draw heavily on cultural images from each culture. This work is not necessarily done in partnership. It often happens at the end of the semester, and can be used as a way to see how what students have discussed with their partners is reflected in such documents.

While the archived discussions reflect what happens between students online, it is important to stress the less visible but essential work that happens between instructors before any conversation can take place between their two groups of students. A *Cultura* exchange is first a collaboration between two instructors across cultures. They must agree on a common calendar; select the materials the students will compare and discuss; review and select the best technological tools to facilitate the students' collaboration. Most importantly, they must discuss expectations, especially regarding students' participation. The question of timely participation on the forums, which is essential but sometimes difficult to achieve, reveals that coordinating work across cultures, between two groups with very different sets of constraints and expectations, can be tricky. It is an opportunity, for both groups, to become aware of the others' context and actively work across differences.

2.0 - How *Cultura* has been made available, accessible and usable by the FL teaching community at large

Cultura is a freely available open educational resource. There are several dimensions to the concept of free availability, however. Even if a resource is *free*, if it is not known to potential users, it cannot be considered *available* in any practical sense. To help *Cultura* serve effectively as an open resource, the creators of *Cultura* and those who have worked closely with them have set forth the principles and practices of this model of intercultural telecollaborative exchange in various professional publications. In addition, researchers have examined *Cultura* as an object of study, and practitioners have reported on their experiences applying or adapting the model. This section focuses on *Cultura*-related works of these various types.

2.1 *Cultura*: Foundational resources

The *Cultura* online platform at MIT, which has been available since 2008 (with some interruption) as an open resource for educators conducting exchanges, facilitates both (1) the administration of surveys, such as word association and sentence completion, and (2) the conduct of learners' bilingual discussions, in which they compare survey results or other juxtaposed artifacts, then put forward and test hypotheses about cultural values based on their comparisons. Past survey results and the ensuing discussions are retained in the site's publicly available *Cultura* archives. The website is an appropriate starting point

for interested practitioners who are seeking guidance in the implementation of their own intercultural online exchanges.

A seminal publication introducing the *Cultura* model, Furstenberg, Levet, et al. (2001), appeared in *Language Learning & Technology*, an open journal with a Journal Impact Factor that hovers around the 90th percentile (Clarivate Analytics, 2018). Additional overviews of *Cultura* can be found in Levet and Waryn (2006), Furstenberg and Levet (2010), Furstenberg and Levet (2014), Levet (2015), and Furstenberg & English (2016). These publications provide both theoretical orientation and practical exposition of how the model can be implemented.

2.2 Publications exploring *Cultura*

The foundational publications mentioned above provide guidance in the use of the *Cultura* model as an open resource for practitioners of intercultural exchange. Such presentations of the “classic” *Cultura* model represent just one type of resource available to interested practitioners, however. In addition, a number of publications have assessed the efficacy of *Cultura* as a resource for intercultural learning, focusing variously on learner acquisition of intercultural competence (ICC) or on features of *Cultura* that motivate and constrain learner behaviors. Other publications, using *Cultura* as a springboard, have offered extensions of the *Cultura* model into educational environments, situations, or populations where it had not previously been employed. Both types of publications reveal the value of *Cultura* as an open resource, both for (1) the examination of the process of the acquisition of intercultural competence and for (2) the development of innovations in educators’ praxis as they seek to facilitate said acquisition. In this section, we will examine selected publications assessing *Cultura* as an educational tool, and in the following section we will examine adaptations and extensions of *Cultura*.

2.2.1 *Cultura*: intercultural learning in the open

The open records at the *Cultura* website have provided a dataset for researchers examining the effectiveness of *Cultura* as a resource for intercultural learning. Of the research publications that have relied on this dataset, a few have notably focused on markers of learner acquisition of intercultural competence, while most publications have focused more on possible effects of the design of *Cultura* itself, or on *Cultura*’s contributions to the online teaching and learning of world languages.

One notable publication focusing on learner acquisition in *Cultura* is Blyth (2012), a study that used the archive to examine French and American stancetaking in online environments, based on many semesters of *Cultura* exchanges between students at MIT and Brown Universities and students at four French universities (Université de Brest, Université de Lille, ENSAM Lille and ENSEIRB-MATMECA). Based on the importance ascribed by John Du Bois (2007) to stancetaking in language use, Blyth (2012) examined “cultural, grammatical, and interactional features of the opinions expressed by French and American college students during telecollaborative discussions of individualism” (p. 49). Analysis of cumulative data from a number of exchanges revealed that culture-based differences in the pragmatics of taking a position posed challenges to students’

cross-cultural communication. Blyth (2012) saw evidence that French and American students' models of the discussion topic were culturally conditioned, and he described the strategies students on both sides of the exchanges used to negotiate their "mismatched" stances (based in their respective home cultures) during online interaction.

Chun (2014b) also examined learner acquisition in a *Cultura*-style exchange between students in the US and in Germany, focusing on intercultural competence (ICC). She found that there was "ample evidence of many students' emerging ICC" (p. 121). In this study, Chun used a modification of the *Cultura* model that combined interaction in the asynchronous forums typical of *Cultura* with additional synchronous chats; moreover, among her subjects a high proportion were multilingual and multicultural, "present[ing] a potentially confounding variable" (p. 105). Chun's focus in this study on genre differences between learners' chat and forum postings, and the links between these genre differences and students' post-hoc assessments of the degree of "success" of specific conversations, is suggestive of the complexity inherent both in assessing learner acquisition in *Cultura* and *Cultura*-like environments and in comparing studies of said acquisition.

Other publications have examined the design of *Cultura* and its effects. Some investigators have identified a salient strength of *Cultura* in contrast to other models for intercultural exchange, namely, the non-prescriptive and emergent nature of cultural knowledge in *Cultura* exchanges in which participants present hypotheses of cultural difference and test them through discussion. Levy (2011), for example, stressed how *Cultura* managed the risk of intercultural conflict through its emphasis on exploratory dialogue. In this assessment, *Cultura* is seen as mitigating cultural conflict through negotiation, which would suggest that the emergent knowledge is not presented as monolithic or essentializing.

But because *Cultura* invites comparison and contrast of phenomena identified with established cultures (e.g., French, American) by students situated in those cultures (though not assumed to be native speakers), and leads them initially to frame this comparison and contrast in terms of those established cultures, *Cultura* has been criticized as facilitating "culturalist discourses" that essentialize cultural differences (Trémion, 2013). This question about the effects of *Cultura*'s structural design was also raised in Koike and Lacorte (2014). In their own publications, the creators of *Cultura* contend that, far from essentializing, *Cultura* attempts to draw students away from stereotyping:

We are not trying to lead our students into believing that, if they write a long enough list of "cultural facts," they will know any better what the other culture is about. We lead them into recognizing a process, and train them to look, make hypotheses, ask questions, reflect on what "culture" is, identifying along the way their own culturally encoded behaviors, becoming more alert and open towards another culture, more flexible, and enriching the way they perceive the world.

Furstenberg & Levet (2014) note that while the initial cultural questionnaires may give a sense of “simplistic... duality”, the subsequent discussions allow for “a much more nuanced and complex view of the cultures at hand” (p. 14). *Cultura*’s positioning as an open educational resource has facilitated the testing of this proposition “in the open,” i.e., using the abovementioned publicly available *Cultura* archives.

Blyth (2015) tested this critique of *Cultura*’s structure, querying whether *Cultura* leads participants inexorably to frame their discourse in culturally essentialist terms by examining the “influence of affordances of the design of *Cultura*’s instructional design on the participants’ discursive perspectives on language and culture” (p. 139). This examination contrasts with Blyth’s (2012) earlier publication by shifting the focus somewhat from learner acquisition to features of the *Cultura* model. Using selections from the same open dataset, Blyth (2015) evaluates whether the parameters established for learner inquiry in the *Cultura* model provide affordances for learners to “explicitly contest culturalist discourses” (p. 141) and to “avoid constructing monolithic representations of national cultures” (p. 161) while exploring differences seen in responses on the French and the American sides of an exchange. Blyth (2015) concludes that “while *Cultura*’s instructional design focuses participants on cultural differences that lead them to construe language and culture as relatively static phenomena” (p. 160), nevertheless, this does “not always lead to essentialist discourses as predicted by the critics” (p. 160). It is interesting to note that the contestation of “essentializing” in *Cultura* can take place very much in the open, both in the sense that the model is freely available and adaptable, and in the sense that the data that serve as a basis for the debate are also freely available.

2.2.2 *Cultura* as referential resource

Apart from publications that examine learner acquisition and the efficacy of *Cultura* in facilitating it, there are a considerable number of works in which *Cultura* is referred to as a potential resource or tool, an exemplar of best practices, or simply as a source of ideas. Since *Cultura* encompasses teacher praxis, the role of the student, the use of technology, the co-construction of knowledge, the definition of “culture,” and many other facets of educational theory and practice, the emphasis on what is “best” about *Cultura* may vary. A number of authors have focused on the integration of technology that enables students in *Cultura* exchanges to connect and communicate. Shrum & Glisan (2016), for example, held up *Cultura* as an effective model for the integration of technology in education. In their instructions for an exercise for pre-service teachers, they shone a spotlight on what they characterized as a serendipitous confluence of practices described in *Cultura* and the student standards developed by the International Society for Technology in Education: “What makes *Cultura* a useful example for ISTE-S is that it does not set out to meet these standards but yet does so through skillfully crafted scaffolded exercises” (Shrum & Glisan 2016, 431). Finkbeiner & Knierim (2006), in their professional development-oriented volume on cultural exchange, made use of *Cultura* as a model for transitioning another model for intercultural exchange to an online format: “we decided to first collect ideas by

following and adapting the *Cultura* design... This helped us gain highly valuable insights into intercultural learning online... allow[ing] for the implementation [of] a web-based learning design” (pp. 213-214). Blake (2008) recognized *Cultura* for having effectively met the challenge of how to use technology to bring learners to a greater understanding of culturally rooted sociolinguistic markers and morphosyntactic structures found in social media.

Other practitioners referring to *Cultura* have focused on pedagogic aspects. Perry (2016), after referring to the word-association comparisons that often constitute the first stage in a *Cultura* exchange, stated “I used this idea in my own classroom to challenge the connotations of some words I felt to be charged with cultural interpretation for Italians and Americans” (p. 17). Orsini-Jones & Lee (2018) cited task designs found in the *Cultura* model, such as the questionnaires, as an inspiration for the design of features of an intercultural telecollaborative project called *CoCo*.

3.0 Adaptations and extensions of *Cultura*

From its beginnings, the *Cultura* project has positioned itself not only as a free and open resource enabling creative adaptation without concern for breaching copyright, but also as a creative hub for the extension of principles and practices that characterize *Cultura* into new domains for telecollaborative exchange. One important result has been the adaptation of the “classic” *Cultura* model into variant forms suited to populations of learners with profiles distinct from the “pioneer” group of university-level learners of French at MIT and their exchange partners in France. From *Cultura*’s early days, educators who have made use of the model as a framework for engaging in intercultural telecollaboration have *adapted* the model to fit the needs of learners in their classes, varying the model along a number of different dimensions. Practitioners have also *extended* the model beyond its original context of foreign language study into the study of language for specific purposes or heritage language learning. Variations in practice in such adaptations and extensions can be motivated by differences in the overarching purpose or topical focus of each exchange, characteristics of student populations, motivations of the instructor, and available instructional resources. As noted in Furstenberg & Levet (2014), “changes in some of the parameters of the original model [might include] the use of L1 or L2 in the forums[,] the type of documents used for comparison[,] the role of the teacher in the online forums[,] and classroom face-to-face discussions” (p. 27). To these we might add the length of the exchange; the use of various tools for communication, such as the mix of synchronous chat and asynchronous forums cited in Chun (2014b) above; the numbers of students on each side of the exchange; and the role the exchange plays in the instructional program or curriculum. In this section we will examine dimensions of variation in adaptations of the *Cultura* model.

3.1 Extension to new languages and contexts of study

The first and most obvious type of variation from the original *Cultura* context, which joined learners of French and English as foreign languages in the United States and France,

respectively, was the extension of the model into other languages. Examples of language pairings in *Cultura*-inspired exchanges have now become too numerous to cite; for a study performed on *Cultura*-inspired exchanges in Spanish and Russian, see Bauer, deBenedette, Furstenberg, Levet & Waryn (2006). Beyond variation in language, extensions of the *Cultura* model into educational contexts beyond postsecondary-level foreign language study are worth mentioning; these include extension into lower (secondary) levels, into heritage language learning contexts, and into language for specific purposes (LSP) contexts. The National Foreign Language Resource Center (NFLRC) at the University of Hawai'i at Mānoa (nflrc.hawaii.edu) has, through several professional development events, served as a "nursery" for the design and delivery of various extensions and adaptations of the *Cultura* model, which are described at the Web site "Online Cafés: Creating Language & Culture Learning Communities" (National Foreign Language Resource Center, 2010 / 2012) (<http://nflrc.hawaii.edu/onlinecafes/>).

By the time the NFLRC proposed the extension of the *Cultura* model into the domain of heritage language learning as the theme of its 2008 Summer Institute, *Cultura* had already been tried at the secondary level. This extension, and other adaptations of the *Cultura* model, were detailed by Gilberte Furstenberg in a PowerPoint presentation (Furstenberg 2008) that oriented Institute participants to the kinds of adaptations that had been made by *Cultura*-inspired practitioners up to that point, preparing them to think about how they would apply the *Cultura* model to exchanges between groups representing heritage members of the same culture either in different locations in diaspora (e.g., Filipino-Americans in Hawai'i and in California), or in-country and in diaspora (e.g., Samoans in American Sāmoa and in Hawai'i). With the aim of "acculturating" learners in these groups to cultural practices and language use as realized in their distinct communities, while facilitating learning of the heritage language (even Samoans in American Sāmoa had limited proficiency in their heritage language), Institute participants designed online exchanges that extended and adapted the *Cultura* model. While these exchanges were not "cross-cultural" in the same sense as "classic" *Cultura*, they used the same strategies of comparison and discussion to uncover areas of similarity and difference and to test hypotheses about variation in their local "microcultures." The Filipino-American Heritage Café is treated in detail in Domingo (2014).

One of the working groups in the NFLRC 2008 Summer Institute worked to extend the *Cultura* model into a business-language LSP context joining students learning Business Chinese in Hawai'i with students learning Business English in China. Adaptations to the *Cultura* model made in this extension centered around the choice of topics and artifacts specific to business; the project is detailed in Jiang, Wang, & Tschudi (2014).

3.2 Adaptations based on purpose and population

One feature of *Cultura* that often surprises new practitioners is the use of L1, both to answer questionnaires and to engage partners in discussion. This "least understood and most widely ignored feature of *Cultura*" (Furstenberg & Levet 2014, 7) serves the functions of equalizing groups (no matter their L2 proficiency level, they are all highly proficient in L1), enabling full freedom of expression (no groping for the *mot juste*), and ensuring

authenticity in linguistic input as well as full embodiment of culture-in-language for the benefit of the collaborative partners. Despite these compelling justifications, quite a number of adaptations of *Cultura* choose to tweak this parameter, most commonly with the aim of providing learners with the chance to develop their productive skills in the L2. Various solutions have included splitting the exchange schedule into blocks of time in which one or the other language is used exclusively, using a lingua franca (as when learners of English language from two different cultures have used English exclusively in *Cultura*-inspired exchanges), or even -- in what might justly be termed a distortion of the model -- having both sides use L2 exclusively in the exchange.

While topics in *Cultura* exchanges at MIT typically involve what might be termed core cultural values, including abstract concepts such as “individualism” or what makes a “good parent,” other exchanges have varied in their topic selection. Exchanges for specific populations may focus on topics of particular interest, such as nurturance of the heritage culture among the heritage students described above. Exchanges of shorter length or among younger learners may narrow topical focus (school and family), while exchanges among highly proficient learners, such as students in the Language Flagships (thelanguageflagship.org), have gone in-depth into topics such as the media in society.

Since *Cultura* is freely available and adaptable, variations often end up looking quite different from the original model -- to the point that it is sometimes difficult to say where “*Cultura*-based adaptations” become a different creature altogether. For example, Vaskivska (2015) involved only one group of students in a cultural-learning activity that made use of archived word-association responses; they were not given the opportunity to engage in hypothesis formation and testing with a partner group. While Vaskivska concludes that “the cultural awareness of L2 learners can also be raised by using archived data from... native speakers” (p. 99), she concedes that “online exchanges would help clarify any incorrect assumptions L2 students might make about the target language and culture based on responses from native speakers” (p. 100). Such latitude in variation is to be expected in the open education landscape.

3.3 *Cultura* and the open education ecosystem

Models for open education stress the benefits of the free and open exchange of ideas and materials, as exemplified in the “About” pages of the Open Education Consortium (2018) and Opensource.com (2018). The gates and controls on academic exchange that characterize the for-profit educational marketplace, such as high textbook prices or paywalls controlling access to publications, are absent or greatly reduced in open education, allowing dialogue about evolving educational models and materials to proceed at a pace limited only by the medium of exchange. In the case of *Cultura*, scholarly exchange and the development of new ideas and resources have taken place through publications and conferences as well as one-on-one communication initiated through the “contact us” link on the website by instructors who have heard about *Cultura* via different channels and are thinking about adapting it. Offering support through direct engagement with potential users is central to the open design philosophy of *Cultura*.

Communication with instructors focuses first on determining what they need: what they know about *Cultura*, where they heard about it, if they have experience with telecollaboration. Instructors planning an exchange may have questions about the different options offered on the website: downloading the *Cultura* Exchange Tool on their own school's server vs. being hosted at MIT, or using other tools such as blogs and Google forms. They check if using *Cultura* is free, how to find a partner, and how much support they can expect. They may have questions on how to manage their exchange, or sometimes need direct assistance with managing their website. This is an opportunity to engage with the instructors and discuss their pedagogical goals and particular challenges, having to do with a wide range of topics: use of L1 and L2, the role of the teacher, what happens in the classroom, exploration of themes from the archives, the types of instructions students need, rules of conduct online. This type of direct support for instructors, developing their exchanges is often time sensitive, and therefore assumes the availability of a supporting team. Keeping *Cultura* going as an open resource entails an investment on the part of MIT, the host institution, in institutional infrastructure, including human resources. In turn, the *Cultura* Project helps to fulfill MIT's institutional commitment to open educational resources. *Cultura's* sustainability depends on this commitment.

CONCLUSION

Cultura's contribution to open education is multifold. It opens the classroom to the world, creating "an open source textbook" (Cha, 2006) generated by students. As the same author notes, "it is not about the technology." It is about an approach and methodology which have been actively shared with educators over the past twenty years. Each *Cultura* exchange is unique, since adaptations in different languages often lead to variations in content and form. But some elements, which constitute the essential aspects of *Cultura*, tend to be present in most exchanges inspired by the original model: the approach is comparative; discussions happen online and in the classroom; the student-generated intercultural questionnaires are usually the first items to be discussed. Because of *Cultura's* modular structure, instructors incorporate into their exchanges different types of documents closely tied to their pedagogical goals, and vary elements of the model to fit their distinct needs. Ideally all the different variations and adaptations of *Cultura* would be accessible online, as was the initial project, to encourage the distribution and exchange of ideas, in keeping with the open philosophy of the project. *Cultura's* active commitment to open education has not only enabled a community of educators to engage with this model, but doing so it has also contributed to the discussion among educators about technology and teaching, the teaching of culture and language, telecollaboration, and now open education.

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